

So you're thinking about transport

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

You've probably been told driving jobs are finished because of self-driving trucks.

We scored twenty-seven careers on AI exposure. Here's what we actually found:

Local delivery: 3.4 out of 10. Long-haul trucking: 4.5. Emergency and specialist vehicles: 2.8.

Logistics planning and scheduling: 7.3.

The person driving is better protected than the person planning their route. That's the opposite of what almost everyone expects, and it's the most useful thing in this document.

The 60-second version

- After nine years of hype, there are **fewer than 50 driver-out trucks** running against about **4 million** Class 8 trucks.
 - Meanwhile dispatch, route planning and brokerage have been substantially automated. Those were the careers.
 - BLS projects 237,600 annual openings** for heavy truck drivers through 2034.
 - Driver pay is **up about 18% since 2020** and hasn't come back down.
 - But turnover at big carriers runs **90–95%** — which tells you something important.
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The prediction that didn't happen

Since about 2017, driving has been the example everyone used for the job AI would kill first.

Where it actually is in mid-2026:

- No commercially scaled, fully driverless freight operations on US highways.
- Aurora, Kodiak and Plus run driver-out pilots on specific corridors in Texas and Arizona
- Fewer than 50 trucks total**, against roughly **4 million Class 8 trucks** nationally
- Even optimistic forecasts put it at 5–10% of long-haul lanes by 2032

That's about one truck in eighty thousand, nine years in.

And three structural things matter more than the current count:

The transfer-hub model keeps humans at both ends. Autonomy targets the highway middle. First mile and last mile — loading docks, city streets, customer sites — stay human by design,

not by delay.

Around 60% of trucking work is stuff autonomy doesn't address at all — dock visits, multi-stop deliveries, hazmat, oversize loads, anything needing interaction at a customer site.

And it doesn't work in winter. Current operations are Sun Belt only.

But here's what *did* get automated

While autonomous trucks were accumulating fifty vehicles, **the back office got rebuilt.**

Warehouse and transport management systems are now standard. AI demand planning is routine. Autonomous picking has moved from pilots into deployment. And industry analysis says dispatch, safety coordination and logistics admin can be offloaded at **30–50% overhead reduction.**

Route planning is the clearest case. Optimising a multi-stop route against traffic, delivery windows, weight limits and driver hours is a maths problem with structured inputs and a measurable right answer. **That's close to a definition of automatable work — and it used to be a career.**

The transferable idea: exposure follows the *shape* of the work, not its status. Physical work in unpredictable places is protected no matter how it's regarded. Screen work on structured inputs is exposed no matter how professional it looks.

The scores

TRACK	SCORE
Emergency & specialist vehicle operation	2.8
Local delivery & multi-stop	3.4
Airline pilot	3.6
Rail operation	4.2
Long-haul trucking	4.5
Freight brokerage & dispatch	6.8
Logistics planning & scheduling	7.3

Which means the normal promotion path — driver, then dispatcher, then planner — moves you toward the exposed end. Every step off the vehicle raises your exposure. That's not a reason never to do it, but it should be a decision rather than an assumed promotion.

About pilots, since it's instructive

Modern airliners can already fly, navigate and land largely automatically. So the manual flying skill people imagine protects pilots isn't actually what protects them.

What protects them is a century of regulation and liability: two qualified humans legally required in the cockpit, certified by national authorities, tested repeatedly, and answerable for the aircraft.

That architecture moves at the speed of international treaty and public confidence — not at the speed of technology.

Worth remembering generally: when a machine can already do a task and humans still do it, look at the law rather than the skill.

What we won't soften

The turnover figures are extraordinary. Large truckload carriers report 90–95% annual driver turnover, and about 35% of new drivers quit within their first 90 days.

That's the honest counterweight to the shortage story. An economist at the University of Pennsylvania, Steve Viscelli, argues the real problem is **retention rather than a shortage of people willing to drive** — an industry losing nine in ten of its workforce every year has a job-quality problem, not a recruitment problem.

We think he's largely right, and it points to the same practical advice: **the segment you choose decides whether this job is sustainable.**

Long-haul over-the-road has the worst conditions and the highest turnover. Local, LTL and specialist work has better pay growth and people stay.

Also honest: long-haul means multiple nights a week away from home — the dominant reason people leave. Injury rates run above average at about 2.8 per 100 workers.

The money

Better than most people assume, and it's risen:

- **Driver wages up around 18% since 2020** — 15.5% in 2022, 7.6% in 2023, 2.4% in 2024
- **Union LTL drivers average ~\$85,000** against ~\$65,000 non-union
- A mid-level over-the-road driver on \$70,000 base costs the carrier \$87,500–\$94,500 all-in
- **No tuition debt.** CDL training is short and frequently employer-funded.

And the demand is demographic: average driver age is about 46, and the ATA estimates the industry needs **1.2 million new drivers over the next decade** just to replace retirements.

Where to actually aim

Local, LTL, specialist and emergency work. Better scores, better pay growth, and where autonomy reaches last.

Get specialist endorsements — hazmat, tanker, oversize, livestock. Higher pay, and the categories autonomy addresses least.

Or look at the technician route. Zero-emission vehicle registrations rose about 40% year-on-year, and high-voltage powertrain technicians barely existed at scale three years ago. Physical, diagnostic work in unpredictable conditions — which is exactly the protected profile — and they're short everywhere.

And plan for ownership. Owner-operator is the realistic route to the top of this industry's income range.

Does this actually sound like you?

It suits people who:

- **Want autonomy during the day** — most of this work is unsupervised. Some people love that; some find it isolating.
- Are **practically competent** and can sort a problem without phoning someone
- Are comfortable being **responsible for an expensive vehicle** and a real safety duty
- Would rather be **paid for competence than for presence**
- Might want to **own something** eventually

Harder if you need social contact through the day, want predictable home life (in long-haul specifically), or find sitting for long stretches physically difficult.

Two things worth doing

Ride along for a full day in the exact segment you're considering. Long-haul, local delivery and specialist work are genuinely different lives, and you can't see the difference from outside.

Then find a driver about ten years in and ask what their body feels like and whether they'd do it again.

And when you're choosing a carrier

Ask two questions: **what's your annual turnover rate**, and **how many nights a week away, realistically?**

With turnover at 90–95% industry-wide, picking the right employer matters more than picking the industry. Compare on turnover and home time — not on sign-on bonus.

One last thing

If someone has told you this career is finished, they were repeating a prediction that's now nine years old and hasn't happened.

And the reason it hasn't isn't that robots are bad at driving. It's that most of this work happens at loading docks, on customer sites and in city streets — and that part was never what anyone was automating.

The technology is real and the timeline is uncertain. Choose the segment that's furthest from the highway, and you're on solid ground.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- [**Heavy and Tractor-trailer Truck Drivers — Occupational Outlook Handbook**](#) — government data on openings and pay. Where the 237,600 figure comes from.
 - [**Truck driver shortage 2026: the real data**](#) — the clearest account of where autonomous trucking actually is, written by someone dispatching for owner-operators.
 - [**ATA industry data**](#) — the industry's own workforce numbers. Worth reading knowing they represent carriers.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the autonomy timeline in detail, what to ask a carrier, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.